

The Entertaible puts a 21st-century spin on the traditional board game

The brainchild of a Philips research team located in Eindhoven in the Netherlands, the Entertaible is a table-top gaming platform that infuses electronics into board games, such as Monopoly or Backgammon. It consists of a 30-inch horizontal LCD table-top unit with a touch screen, and is designed to work in any lighting conditions.

The Entertaible is called so because of the social “entertainment” experience it offers, and its “table-top” form factor. It incorporates the use of traditional board game features such as dice and pawns, and has “multi-object position detection,” meaning that it simultaneously detects the location of several different objects, including fingers, on the screen. So you can play, for example, Monopoly, with the Entertaible detecting the positions of various players’ fingers as well as those of the game pieces.

The capabilities and features of this innovation could bring true interactivity to multi-player board and electronic games. For example, you could use a portion of the touch-screen to allow private tactical information to be shown only to specific players.

Electronic gaming is generally considered isolating; the Entertaible provides an opportunity for social interaction. You can store many different board games, have several game levels, save a game in mid-play, and have rules explained as you play through a game!

Showcased at the Consumer Electronics Show 2006, the Entertaible is currently in the prototype stage. It will be first targeted at restaurants, pubs, bars and casinos. The good folks at Philips may come up with a home version if the present model is a success, and we’re keeping our fingers crossed!



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